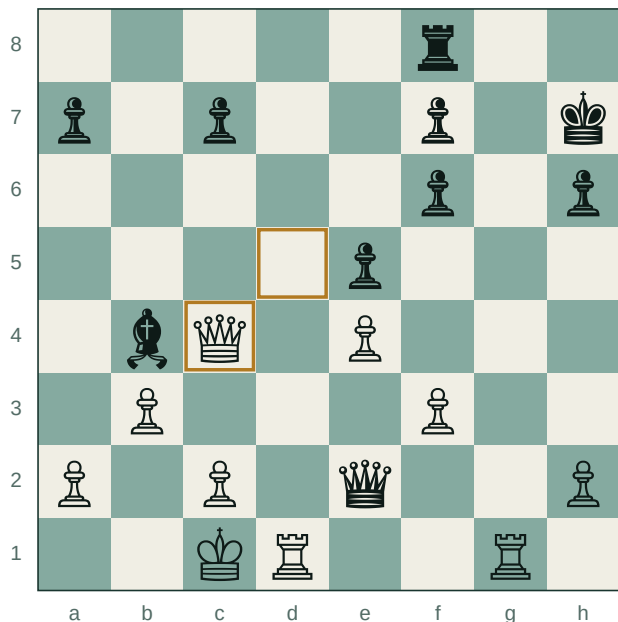


Queenside attacks: Black, move 26

Queenside attacks

Black to move



Previous move: 26.Qc4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26...Ba3+ 27. Kb1 Qxc4 28. bxc4 Rb8+ 29. Ka1 Bb2+

26...Ba3+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **27.Kb1**.

27...Qxc4 The queen captures the queen on c4. Recorded reply: **28.bxc4**.

28...Rb8+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **29.Ka1**.

29...Bb2+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here.

At the end, nominal material is White 16 / Black 14 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +0. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +0:** the balance goes from -2 to -2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The board's left half is not inherently safe. Queen checks and rook entries can make a queenside king as vulnerable as a kingside one.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An attack on the queenside can target a castled king, a vulnerable pawn, or trapped pieces. Files and entry squares matter more than simply advancing flank pawns.

HOW TO LOOK

Locate the critical target and which pawn or piece move opens a route toward it. Check whether central counterplay interrupts the plan.

The defending king is on c1. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.